

SpiceJet Service Operations Analysis

A structured service-operations study connecting service quality, customer value, process design, waiting psychology, capacity and recovery.

5	4.46/10	7.27/10	34.5–34.6%
RATER dimensions	SpiceJet PUV	Akasa benchmark	July 2026 OTP

THE CORE IDEA

Identify where SpiceJet's service promise breaks down, trace failures to operational and process constraints, and prioritise actions that rebuild reliability without sacrificing the low-cost value proposition.

WHAT WAS ANALYSED

Workstream	What was done
Service quality	Applied SERVQUAL/RATER to identify expectation–delivery gaps.
Service strategy	Positioned SpiceJet against Indian low-cost airline peers on price and reliability.
Customer value	Built a weighted PUV comparison with Akasa Air.
Process design	Mapped the passenger journey using Service Blueprinting.
Experience & recovery	Applied Servicescape, Queue Psychology and the LEARN recovery model.
Operations	Examined location strategy, demand/capacity/yield and service inventory.

01 • SERVICE QUALITY

Where the service gap is largest

SERVQUAL / RATER was used as the diagnostic backbone, translating each dimension into an aviation-specific customer expectation.

THE CORE FINDING

Reliability and responsiveness show the clearest expectation–delivery gap, while assurance and empathy weaken particularly during disruption.

Dimension	Customer expectation	Observed gap	Priority
Reliability	Flights operate as promised.	Recurring delays/cancellations and weak schedule reliability.	Severe
Responsiveness	Fast updates and help during disruption.	Long waits and limited real-time communication.	Severe
Assurance	Confidence in refunds and compensation.	Reported disputes and escalation needs.	High
Empathy	Basic care during long disruption.	Passenger-care expectations not consistently met.	High
Tangibles	Comfortable, functioning cabin.	Recurring cabin thermal/AC issues.	Moderate

DIAGNOSIS

The analysis attributes the service-quality problem primarily to delivery and resource constraints rather than a fundamentally flawed low-cost proposition. The strategic response is therefore to stabilise execution, not abandon price leadership.

MANAGERIAL IMPLICATION

Time horizon	Priority action
0–6 months	Stabilise delivery; align growth with crew and ground-staff capacity; introduce an IRROPS communication protocol.
6–18 months	Rebuild trust through automated refund/compensation workflows and transparent reliability reporting.
18+ months	Scale fleet only when maintenance and staffing capacity can support reliable delivery.

02 • CUSTOMER VALUE & PRIORITISATION

What passengers value — and where effort should go

The project combined a weighted Perceived User Value assessment with Importance–Performance logic to separate strengths worth protecting from urgent weaknesses.

4.46/10	7.27/10	63%	3
SpiceJet PUV	Akasa PUV	Akasa weighted PUV advantage	Urgent-action attributes

THE CORE IDEA

SpiceJet's strongest relative advantages are affordability and network reach. The largest customer-value deficits sit in reliability and service — attributes passengers weight heavily.

Attribute	Weight	SpiceJet	Akasa	Action
On-time performance	20	2	8	Urgent
Fare affordability	20	9	7	Protect
Schedule reliability	15	2	8	Urgent
Customer service	15	2	7	Urgent
Cabin & aircraft comfort	12	4	8	Improve

Attribute	Weight	SpiceJet	Akasa	Action
Network reach	10	7	5	Appropriate / protect
Digital booking	8	6	7	Lower priority

STRATEGIC READ

The issue is not simply that SpiceJet performs poorly. Its effort appears misallocated: breadth and digital experience are relatively stronger, while reliability fundamentals remain weak. The implication is to shift resources toward operational consistency while preserving the low-fare proposition.

03 • SERVICE PROCESS & EXPERIENCE

Finding the failure inside the passenger journey

Service Blueprinting and Servicescape analysis distinguished visible customer-facing failures from backstage process and physical-environment failures.

CASE MAPPED			
Delhi–Pune SG-105, 11 Aug 2026: boarding → cabin AC failure → approximately two-hour tarmac wait → limited explanation → replacement aircraft → completion of journey.			
Journey stage	Customer experience	Backstage / support issue	Design implication
Boarding	Passenger boards normally.	Technical readiness of cabin environment was not sufficiently verified.	Add a formal pre-boarding technical-readiness gate.
On-ground hold	Waits on tarmac with limited explanation.	Replacement aircraft process lacks a strong frontstage handoff.	Define ownership and escalation triggers.
Communication	Passengers seek real-time information.	No consistent disruption script/update cadence.	Standardise PA/SMS/app updates.
Recovery	Eventually continues on replacement aircraft.	Operational recovery exists, but human communication is incomplete.	Combine operational recovery with empathy and explanation.

SERVICESCAPE INSIGHT

The physical environment was analysed by control: cabin AC/thermal comfort, crew conduct and in-flight ambience sit within the airline's controllable zone, while terminal layout and airport queues are primarily airport-controlled.

KEY PROCESS GAP

The most important blueprint break occurs at the handoff between backstage technical readiness and frontstage passenger communication. The recommendation is therefore a process-control intervention, not simply another customer-service initiative.

04 • WAITING & SERVICE RECOVERY

Turning a disruption into a recovery opportunity

Queue Psychology and the LEARN model were applied to understand why the same physical delay can create very different levels of dissatisfaction.

THE WAITING PROBLEM		
An approximately two-hour on-tarmac wait combined uncertainty, limited activity and weak explanation — conditions that make perceived waiting time feel substantially worse.		
LEARN step	Assessment	What the analysis found
Listen	FAIL	Passenger accounts describe a weak response to concerns during the disruption.
Empathize	FAIL	Distress was not consistently acknowledged from the passenger perspective.
Apologise	PASS	A public regret/apology statement was issued.
Recover	PASS	A replacement aircraft was arranged and the journey completed.
Notify	FAIL	The explanation and passenger experience were not consistently aligned.

RECOVERY DIAGNOSIS

SpiceJet demonstrates a recovery mechanism — replacement/rebooking and apology — but the project identified a weaker recovery culture at the frontline. The human layer of recovery is therefore as important as the operational fix.

RECOMMENDED OPERATING STANDARD

Trigger	Frontline standard
Technical hold > 15 min	Proactive PA/text/app update at a fixed cadence, even when the root cause is not yet fully known.
Disruption > 60 min	Activate IRROPS protocol with visible ownership, passenger-care checks and escalation.
Recovery action	Pair operational solution with acknowledgement, empathy and a clear explanation.

05 • CAPACITY, LOCATION & INVENTORY

Connecting service failures to operations

The project moved upstream from customer experience to the operational system supporting service delivery: fleet, route structure, demand, maintenance and spare-parts capacity.

THE OPERATIONS STORY
Demand remained relatively resilient, but fleet availability became unstable. This constrained network capacity and amplified downstream reliability and service-experience gaps.

Area	Analysis	Conclusion
Location strategy	Delhi hub + 737 metro routes + Q400 Tier-2/3 regional routes.	Underlying network logic is sound; execution is capacity-constrained.
Demand / capacity	Strong PLF alongside a volatile active fleet.	Yield discipline exists, but capacity planning is not fully a strategic choice.
Inventory / maintenance	Evidence links overhaul/spare constraints with grounded aircraft and reduced capacity.	Treat spare-parts root cause as an evidence-based inference, not company-confirmed fact.
Fleet recovery	Growth toward a larger fleet was assessed against staffing and maintenance capacity.	Growth should be gated by reliable operational readiness.

KEY METRICS USED

84%+	 4.04	~26→60	300+
Passenger load factor	PRASK cited in analysis	Targeted fleet recovery path	Targeted daily flights

MANAGERIAL IMPLICATION

When capacity is constrained, the airline should protect the routes and capacity uses that create the most strategic value rather than spreading an unstable fleet too thin. Reliability should be treated as a prerequisite for sustainable growth.

06 • FINAL INTEGRATION

From individual gaps to one operating-system diagnosis

The final stage connected the frameworks into a single causal chain and translated the analysis into a prioritised action agenda.

CORE OBJECTIVE	
Maintain the low-cost value proposition while rebuilding operational reliability and customer experience — not one at the expense of the other.	
System layer	Finding
Demand	Customer demand remained relatively resilient; seats were still being filled.
Capacity	Fleet volatility constrained the ability to deliver a stable schedule.
Service process	The passenger journey breaks at key technical/frontstage handoffs.
Waiting	Unexplained, unoccupied waits intensify dissatisfaction.
Service failure	AC, delays and cancellations become visible symptoms of deeper constraints.
Recovery	Operational recovery exists, but empathy and communication need strengthening.
Service quality	Reliability and responsiveness are the dominant gaps.
Customer value	PUV trails the peer benchmark despite price advantage.
Competitive position	Low fares remain an asset, but trust is the strategic deficit.

PRIORITISED RECOMMENDATIONS

Priority	Action
01 • Fix the root cause	Resolve maintenance/spare and engine-overhaul constraints; stabilise aircraft availability before aggressive capacity expansion.
02 • Institutionalise the human layer	Embed LEARN-based frontline behaviour and a formal IRROPS communication protocol.
03 • Protect what is winning	Retain fare affordability and network reach while redirecting effort toward reliability fundamentals.

PROJECT TAKEAWAY

This project demonstrates the ability to integrate multiple Service Operations frameworks into one managerial diagnosis — moving from customer perception, to process design, to operational constraints, and finally to actionable recommendations.

Source: Group 2 Service Operations presentation provided for portfolio documentation.